



This engraving on wood depicts Brandenburg forces storming Polish positions at the Battle of Warsaw in 1656 during the First Northern War.

4,600,000 SQUARE MILES

THE APPROXIMATE SIZE OF THE EMPIRE CLAIMED BY PORTUGAL

FEARFUL OF RUSSIAN DOMINATION OF THE BALTIC,

Sweden entered the Thirteen Years' War between Russia and Poland-Lithuania in 1655, thus creating the **First Northern War**. Other countries were sucked in and alliances changed. In 1656,

the Polish capital Warsaw was taken by a Swedish-Brandenburg force, further **undermining the Polish-Lithuanian state**.

One of the **greatest paintings in Western culture** was created in 1656 when Spanish artist Diego Velázquez (1599–1660) painted

Las Meninas, an enigmatic work that has been hugely influential.

A renewed phase of **Ottoman** confidence began when Köprülü Mehmed (1575–1661) became **grand vizier** in 1656, Sultan Mehmed IV handing him control of the empire. He ruthlessly stamped out opposition and embarked on a series of military campaigns—completed after his death in 1661—that saw the **empire at its greatest extent**.

Las Meninas

Diego Velázquez's painting of Margarita, the daughter of Philip IV of Spain, and her entourage, is known for its complex composition.



A manuscript showing Ottoman troops on the island of Lemnos.

ON MARCH 2, 1657, the **Great Fire of Meireki** began in Edo (Tokyo).

In two days, fed by relentless winds, it destroyed almost 70 percent of the city, consuming the paper and wooden buildings and **killing around 100,000** people.

Although an offshoot of the First Northern War, the **Swedish-Danish Wars** of 1657–58 and 1658–60 developed into a largely separate conflict over control of the Baltic when, in June 1657, Denmark joined the coalition confronting Sweden in Poland. Sweden had made consistent **gains at Denmark's expense** since the mid-16th century; the prize, control of The Sound—the strategically and economically vital entrance to the Baltic—still under Danish control in 1657. In the winter of 1657–58, Charles X of Sweden (1622–60) outflanked the Danes, marching his troops into Denmark and then, in February, across the frozen Baltic to Copenhagen itself. The **Treaty of Roskilde** in 1658 confirmed Sweden's territorial dominance. The second war, if less favorable to Sweden, still underlined **Sweden's Baltic superiority**.

With the Ottoman Empire now reinvigorated by Grand Vizier Köprülü Mehmed, in late 1657 its fleet **captured the Aegean islands of Lemnos and Tenedos** from the Venetians. The islands, which dominated the approaches to the Dardanelles, had been used by the Venetians to **blockade Constantinople**, the Ottoman capital. The Venetians would not pose such a threat again.



IN JUNE 1658, AURANGZEB

(1618–1707), or Alamgir ("Conqueror of the World") as he called himself, was **crowned Mughal emperor**. It ended two years of infighting between him and his brothers for their father, Shah Jahan's, throne—this despite Shah Jahan still being alive. All three **brothers were subsequently executed** (two by Aurangzeb). His reign would prove paradoxical. Mughal India was still immensely rich and powerful. Under Aurangzeb, a devout Muslim, it reached its **greatest territorial extent** (see p.234). Yet the near continuous warfare of his 49-year reign, in which immense



Conqueror of the World
This portrait of the Mughal emperor, Aurangzeb I, seen with his courtiers, is attributed to the Indian artist Bhawani Das.

- March 25, 1655** Saturn's largest moon, Titan, discovered by Christian Huygens
- 1655** Manchurians advance into Siberia
- 1655** First Northern War sees Sweden, Russia, Denmark, and Poland-Lithuania in conflict
- May 1655** England seizes Jamaica from Spain
- January 1656** Treaty of Königsberg allies Sweden and Brandenburg
- October 15, 1655** Jews of Lublin, Poland, massacred
- 1656** Köprülü Mehmed becomes grand vizier of Ottoman Empire
- 1656** Velázquez paints *Las Meninas*, masterpiece of Spanish Baroque
- 1656** Mughals force Deccan sultanate to pay tribute and cede territory
- July 1656** Warsaw captured by Swedish-Brandenburg army
- December 1656** Pendulum clock invented by Dutch mathematician Christiaan Huygens
- 1656** Dutch capture Colombo, Ceylon, from Portuguese Empire at its height

- January** Great Fire of Meireki, Japan
- August** Quakers arrive in New Amsterdam, North America
- Danish-Swedish War** begins
- Ottomans** seize Tenedos and Lemnos from Venice
- November** Brandenburg and Poland allied against Sweden

- February 26, 1658** Treaty of Roskilde. Sweden gains southern Scandinavian peninsula from Denmark
- 1658** Dutch complete capture of Ceylon from Portugal
- June 1658** Battle of the Dunes sees Anglo-French force defeat Spanish; Dunkirk ceded to England (to 1662)
- 1658** Aurangzeb proclaims himself Mughal emperor